

# A Living Map of Sacred Literature — Project Brief

*The cornerstone document. When in doubt, this file wins. Hand it to any AI assistant at the start of a session so it builds what we actually mean.*

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## 1. What this is

A **free, open-access, interactive educational resource** — a timeline and an ancient map — that shows how religious literature developed, from the **Kesh Temple Hymn (c. 2600 BCE)** through **early Christianity (c. 150 CE)**.

It is built by **directing an AI in plain English** ("vibe-coding"), not by hand-writing code.

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## 2. Guiding philosophy — the cornerstone

The project exists to **educate, not persuade**. It is **descriptive, not argumentative**. For every text, tradition, or historical claim, it must:

- **Distinguish four things clearly:** historical evidence · scholarly consensus · alternative scholarly views · speculative connections.
- **Show a confidence level** where appropriate: **well-established** · **probable** · **debated** · **speculative**.
- **Cite reliable academic sources** whenever possible.
- **Never present a disputed theory as settled fact.**

It should invite people to explore the evidence themselves by showing **when, where, by whom, and in what cultural context** each text was composed, preserved, and transmitted. The values are **transparency, historical rigor, and respect for scholarly uncertainty** — so that users of any background or belief can investigate and draw their own conclusions.

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## 3. Scope guardrail — stay macro

Work at the level of **major texts, traditions, peoples, and empires**. Avoid descending into every denomination, sect, school, or philosophical sub-branch unless a specific one genuinely

carries the historical story. **Breadth and clarity over exhaustive subdivision.** We can always zoom in later; we do not start there.

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#### 4. How the app handles uncertainty (rules it must follow)

- Every dated item shows a **date range** plus a **confidence tier** (well-established / probable / debated / speculative).
  - Every significant claim is **tagged by type** (evidence / consensus / alternative view / speculative connection).
  - **Influence links between texts are styled by claim type** — for example: solid line = documented literary dependency; dashed = probable; dotted = debated or speculative — and each link carries a short note and a source.
  - **Sources appear on every entry.** Disputed things are shown as disputed.
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#### 5. Technology decisions (all free; AI-built)

- **Plain JavaScript + React + Vite.** (TypeScript can come much later, if ever.)
  - **A custom hand-drawn vector map**, not a modern map library — so the world stays ancient (rivers, coasts, cities, regions) instead of looking like a present-day political map. D3 used where helpful.
  - Later: **QGIS** for serious historical geography; **Inkscape** optional.
  - **Two homes for the work:**
    1. *This chat* — a fast design studio for trying ideas (no setup).
    2. *Claude Code on the Mac* — the permanent project that can be saved, version-controlled with Git/GitHub, and **published free** (e.g. GitHub Pages or Netlify) so it is genuinely open-access.
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#### 6. Data model (what one entry looks like)

**Each text:** title · date range · confidence tier · claim type · origin place · city · people / civilization · language · script · religious tradition · literary genre · short summary · historical significance · sources · influences (each: which text, relationship, claim type, short note).

**Each people/culture:** name · active date range · short note. **Each place:** name · approximate location · short note.

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## 7. Roadmap (always keep a working version at every step)

- **Phase 1 — done (preview):** map + timeline + ~18 texts + culture bands + influence lines + info panel.
  - **Phase 2:** flesh out ~20–30 core texts with real sources and the four-tier tagging.
  - **Phase 3:** gentle animation of peoples and cities over time (empires kept schematic and honest about uncertainty).
  - **Phase 4:** a dedicated influence view, styled by claim type.
  - **Phase 5:** plant the project in Claude Code on the Mac, publish it free and open-access, and grow the database.
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## 8. Standing sources

ETCSL (Sumerian literature) · ORACC (cuneiform corpus) · Pleiades (ancient places), plus reputable critical editions and scholarly handbooks. Prefer scholarly consensus; flag alternative views; label speculation as speculation.